

Skillshare: Networking & Collaboration in Astronomy

Building the collaborations that shape your career

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Based on collected advice from RSAA faculty and postdocs.

“Your colleagues of tomorrow are in your meetings today.”

Why Networking Matters

Modern astronomy is collaborative

- ▶ Surveys
- ▶ Instruments
- ▶ Software
- ▶ Ideas
- ▶ Careers

Most opportunities come through people who know your work.

Reframing Networking

Networking is NOT:

- ▶ collecting business cards
- ▶ talking to famous people only

Networking IS:

- ▶ finding shared interests
- ▶ helping each other & building trust
- ▶ scientific curiosity

“Scientists love to know, but love even more to talk about their science.”

Collaboration Map

Careers are shaped through people

- ▶ peers (aka former students)
- ▶ surveys
- ▶ unexpected collaborations
- ▶ interdisciplinary links

Unexpected Paths

Smaller collaborations are often not planned

- ▶ conference coffee chats
- ▶ asking a question after a talk
- ▶ software help becoming a paper
- ▶ side discussions becoming projects

Small interactions can have long-term consequences.

Advice from Scientists

- ▶ “Do things because you are curious.”
- ▶ “Things always take longer than expected.”
- ▶ “Network with students and ECRs.”
- ▶ “Do not take your results personally.”
- ▶ “Build genuine human relationships.”

What Can You Offer?

Networking is not only about what you gain

Skills

coding help, observing help, data analysis

Ideas

questions, perspectives, curiosity

Reliability

follow-through, communication, support

Before a Conference

Before the conference:

- ▶ look at the program
 - ▶ identify people/projects and read their latest papers
 - ▶ prepare 2–3 questions
 - ▶ optional: contact people early so they have seen your name
- Conferences are easier when you have a conversation starter.*

During a Conference

Good networking moments:

- ▶ after talks
- ▶ poster sessions
- ▶ coffee breaks
- ▶ conference dinners
- ▶ walks between sessions

You do not need many conversations. You need meaningful ones.

Starting Conversations

Easy conversation starters

- ▶ “I enjoyed your talk/slides/animation/metaphor because...”
- ▶ “How did you get into this project?”
- ▶ “What are you excited about right now?”
- ▶ “How is this problem evolving?”
- ▶ “I am doing research in ... Is there anything that I could contribute to?”

Listening Matters

“Let them do the talking.”

- ▶ ask follow-up questions
- ▶ be genuinely curious
- ▶ people remember good listeners
- ▶ senior people will often share exciting ideas (that they may not work on)

Following Up

After the conference:

- ▶ short email/message
- ▶ paper link
- ▶ code/resource
- ▶ proof-of-concept plot for a science idea
- ▶ future coffee/chat

Most collaborations grow slowly.

Pitch Exercise

Goal: Know your audience

Your pitch needs to change depending who you talk to: - an expert in your field - an astronomer in a different field - a non-astronomer (who care more about ... than astronomy) - an funding agency/industry partner/public audience

Bad vs Good Pitch

Bad

- ▶ assuming they already know it all
- ▶ jargon
- ▶ too many details
- ▶ no clear message
- ▶ you do not try to connect with them on a personal level

Good

- ▶ enthusiasm
- ▶ clear problem

Exercise Time: Pitch to a specific audience

3 minutes preparation

2 minutes each

Listener gives feedback

Listener: Take a moment to imagine being ... Pitcher: Focus on curiosity and connecting to your listener, not perfection.

Reflection

What worked?

What felt difficult?

What made people interested?

Optional: (Where) Did the pitcher lose your attention?

Key Insight

*Different audiences do not need different science.
They need different entry points.*

Your Peers Matter

Your future collaborators are often:

- ▶ current students
- ▶ postdocs
- ▶ workshop colleagues
- ▶ your supervisor's network

People grow together scientifically.

Reliability Matters

People remember:

- ▶ reliability
- ▶ kindness
- ▶ good communication
- ▶ follow-through

More than: - perfect brilliance

Networking works best when you:

- ▶ are genuinely curious
- ▶ help others
- ▶ stay in touch
- ▶ think long-term

Good science is built by communities.

The remaining 2026 Skillshares

- ▶ 9 June 2026: Near-Peers Advice Panel
- ▶ 14 July 2026: Technical Skill MCMC Uncertainty Estimation
- ▶ 11 August 2026: Structuring Papers and Talks Around Impactful Figures
- ▶ 8 September 2026: Setting Up Applications and CVs
- ▶ 13 October 2026: Research Statements and First Fellowship Page
- ▶ 10 November 2026: Mock Interviews
- ▶ 8 December 2026: Providing Feedback (e.g. Refereeing Papers)

Would you want to switch with a different topic? e.g. people management (upwards & downwards) or project management?